Compensatory Faking and the Relationship Between Cognitive Ability and Personality in Personnel Selection: Meta-Analytic Evidence and Trait-Driven Simulations

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Study 1 is a secondary analysis of the publicly available Personality Traits and Cognitive Abilities Relations Database (Stanek & Ones, 2023c), https://doi.org/10.13020/7YS8-ET75, used under a CC BY-NC-ND 3.0 US license. The database is not redistributed. The authors of the database were not involved in the design, analysis, or reporting of the present study. All analysis and simulation code and the aggregate tables and figures are available from the author until a public repository is posted; the database itself is not part of these materials. The studies' research questions and analysis plans were not preregistered. The author received no external funding for this research and declares no conflicts of interest.

Neither study collected data from human participants: Study 1 analyzes previously published aggregate correlations from the public database above; Study 2 is a computer simulation. No institutional review board approval was required. Vocentive (San Francisco, CA) is the institution responsible for this work. Correspondence concerning this article should be addressed to Matthew J. Monnot, Vocentive, San Francisco, CA. Email: matt@vocentive.com

Abstract

Personality inventories are widely used in employee selection, and their self-report format is susceptible to applicant response distortion. Two studies examined distortion through the correlation between personality and general mental ability (GMA). Study 1 meta-analyzed the largest available database of personality–ability correlations, comparing genuine applicant samples (N = 13,137–22,775) with incumbent, student, and community samples (N = 130,377–188,410). The Conscientiousness–GMA correlation reversed sign, from $\bar{r}$ = .03 among incumbents to −.07 among applicants (Δ = −.11, 95% CI [−.18, −.03]), and the reversal was concentrated in non-US selection settings. The other Big Five factors showed no applicant–incumbent differences, a trait-specific pattern consistent with compensatory faking and inconsistent with trait-general distortion. A Monte Carlo model fit to the meta-analytic estimates indicated that, at 40% faking prevalence, such distortion changes 22%–36% of top-down hiring decisions and lowers mean hire performance by 8%–19%. Study 2 modeled who fakes, assigning faking from applicant traits anchored to published trait–faking correlations; the meta-analytic evidence rejected desirability-proportional (trait-general) inflation. Applicants who gained hiring slots through modeled faking averaged 0.2–0.4 standard deviations lower in honesty-humility than those they displaced (0.3–0.7 under overt integrity-test correlations), while adverse-impact ratios were essentially unchanged.

Keywords: applicant faking, validity–diversity trade-off, personnel selection, conscientiousness, Monte Carlo simulation

Compensatory Faking and the Relationship Between Cognitive Ability and Personality in Personnel Selection: Meta-Analytic Evidence and Trait-Driven Simulations

Personality inventories are among the most widely used tools in employee selection (Hough & Oswald, 2008; Rothstein & Goffin, 2006), and the people who complete them during hiring have every reason to present themselves well. Applicants score roughly half a standard deviation higher than nonapplicants on Conscientiousness and Emotional Stability (d = 0.45 and 0.44; Birkeland et al., 2006). Within-person studies of genuine applicants indicate that 30%–50% elevate their scores meaningfully relative to how they respond when nothing is at stake (Donovan et al., 2014; Griffith et al., 2007), and a synthesis of direct and indirect evidence concludes that roughly 30% (±10%) of applicants fake (Griffith & Converse, 2011). Distortion of this kind affects selection outcomes. It changes who reaches the top of a ranked applicant pool (Mueller-Hanson et al., 2003), attenuates the criterion-related validity of personality scores (Speer et al., 2025), and alters the factor structure of applicant responses (Schmit & Ryan, 1993).

The correlation between personality scores and general mental ability (GMA) scores offers one measurable indicator of applicant response distortion. Ability scores are difficult to inflate, so GMA provides a stable reference point against which distortion in self-reported personality can be detected. If applicants differ in how much they inflate their self-reports, that inflation alters the covariance between the personality and ability measures. In turn, variation in the correlation across assessment contexts can reveal who distorts and how much distortion affects selection decisions.

Accurate estimates of the correlation between GMA and personality in a selection context are important for several reasons. When a personality inventory is administered alongside a GMA test, the incremental validity of the personality measure is a direct function of the

correlation between the two predictors (Schmidt & Hunter, 1998). Also, analyses of composite validity and composite subgroup differences require predictor intercorrelations as input values (De Corte et al., 2007; Ployhart & Holtz, 2008; Sackett & Ellingson, 1997), as do the Pareto-optimal weighting methods used in modern selection procedures (Berry et al., 2024; De Corte et al., 2022; Song et al., 2017). Finally, when local validation samples are small, meta-analytic estimates are the recommended inputs for these methods (Tang et al., 2026). Personality–intelligence meta-analyses often aggregate correlations from students, community volunteers, and employees who completed inventories for research purposes, and their published estimates pool across assessment contexts (Ackerman & Heggestad, 1997; Stanek & Ones, 2023a). Recent aggregate GMA–Conscientiousness meta-analytic evidence suggests a small positive relationship (r = .03; Berry et al., 2024); however, the strength of the relationship may be influenced by context.

Faking behavior is itself correlated with cognitive ability, both in laboratory studies (Christiansen et al., 2005; Geiger et al., 2018; Schilling et al., 2021; Vasilopoulos et al., 2005) and in applicant settings (Schmit & Ryan, 1993). If the applicants who distort their responses differ in GMA from those who do not, then the personality–GMA correlation in a selection context has important practical implications. Selection research already treats predictor intercorrelations as setting specific when samples are range restricted, and Sackett et al. (2007) cautioned against assuming that values estimated in one setting apply in another. Faking, a response bias in which intentionally inflated responses cluster near the scale ceiling, shrinking observed variance and contaminating the measured construct (Hu & Connelly, 2021; Schmit & Ryan, 1993), has received no comparable treatment. The evidence that stakes alter the personality–GMA correlation rests largely on laboratory and instructed-faking designs (e.g.,

Christiansen et al., 2005; MacCann, 2013; Vasilopoulos et al., 2005). The nearest meta-analysis compared selection with nonselection situations, and its selection-context correlations were substantially larger in laboratory paradigms than in genuine hiring settings (Schilling et al., 2021). Applicant and nonapplicant samples have otherwise been compared meta-analytically only on mean scores (Birkeland et al., 2006). No meta-analysis has compared personality–GMA correlations between genuine applicant samples and incumbents assessed for research purposes. None has tested whether the stakes contrast extends to facets and compound traits, and none has quantified what context-dependent intercorrelations mean for selection research.

The present research uses meta-analytic moderator analyses (Schmidt & Hunter, 2015; Steel & Kammeyer-Mueller, 2002) in the largest available database of personality–ability correlations to compare genuine applicant samples with lower-stakes samples. It also examines three theoretical perspectives that make competing predictions about the direction of correlational differences. Next, a Monte Carlo simulation translates these estimates into practical consequences for selection decisions. Together, the two studies contribute a construct-by-construct comparison of genuine applicant and incumbent samples in the largest available personality–ability database, a test, against that meta-analytic evidence, of competing explanations of who fakes and how, and simulation evidence that trait-driven faking changes the composition of who is hired in ways that standard selection statistics miss. The analyses also supply context-matched intercorrelation estimates for selection researchers who currently have only low-stakes values available.

The Compensatory Faking Hypothesis

Whether applicant distortion alters the personality–GMA correlation, and in which direction, depends on who fakes and by how much. Theoretical models of applicant faking

converge on the proposition that faking requires both motivation and capability (McFarland & Ryan, 2000, 2006; Snell et al., 1999). The motivational branch of these models generates what is termed here the compensatory faking hypothesis. The label is distinct from the compensation hypothesis of the ability-personality development literature (Moutafi et al., 2004; Wood & Englert, 2009), which holds that less able individuals develop greater conscientiousness over time; the present account concerns response distortion within an assessment, not trait development, and it predicts a difference between applicant and incumbent correlations that a developmental account does not. The proximal driver of faking motivation is the perceived need to fake. Applicants distort their responses to the degree that they perceive a discrepancy between their actual standing and what the job demands (Goffin & Boyd, 2009). In expectancy terms, applicants who do not expect to compete successfully through honest responding assign the highest instrumentality to distortion (Ellingson & McFarland, 2011).

Compensatory faking is activated by the person in the situation, not by the assessment devices themselves. Lower-standing applicants have the strongest motivation to elevate their self-presentations wherever elevation is possible, and the high-stakes application context supplies the incentive that research administrations lack (Ellingson & McFarland, 2011; Goffin & Boyd, 2009). A directional prediction for the personality–GMA correlation nonetheless follows, because only one of the two measures leaves room for distortion. If lower-ability applicants inflate their personality scores more than higher-ability applicants do, a negative correlation between GMA and observed personality scores emerges in applicant samples even when none exists among honest responders. Incentivized faking concentrates prediction error at the top of the faked score distribution, and fakers selected under stringent selection ratios show lower true performance than their honest counterparts (Mueller-Hanson et al., 2003).

Because some trait content is more transparently job relevant than other content, compensation further predicts trait specificity. Applicant–incumbent comparisons show the largest mean elevations for Conscientiousness (d = 0.45) and Emotional Stability (d = 0.44), with a smaller, nonsignificant elevation for Agreeableness (d = 0.16, 95% CI [−0.01, 0.32]; Birkeland et al., 2006), an ordering that tracks how directly each trait signals job competence. The negative shift should therefore concentrate on the most evaluative content, above all Conscientiousness, and should be absent for less evaluative content such as Openness, whose applicant elevation is small (d = 0.13; Birkeland et al., 2006).

Two Competing Perspectives

Two alternative perspectives begin from the same premise. First, a trait-general perspective treats socially desirable responding as a pervasive response style that elevates all evaluative content and compresses true-score variance (Ones et al., 1996). Uniform elevation attenuates correlations across all traits. This uniform attenuation does not, however, produce sign reversals on particular traits. Second, faking may instead be an ability-dependent skill. Successful distortion requires identifying what the test rewards, which draws on cognitive ability (Klehe et al., 2012; Kleinmann et al., 2011). Self-presentation theory frames faking as adaptive performance that more capable applicants execute more effectively (Marcus, 2009). The direct evidence is substantial. Cognitive ability predicts successful score inflation, particularly on cognitively demanding formats (Christiansen et al., 2005; Vasilopoulos et al., 2005); instructed faking draws on crystallized intelligence (MacCann, 2013); psychometrically measured faking ability is largely explained by cognitive abilities (Geiger et al., 2018); and a meta-analysis of 115 samples found higher cognitive ability–personality correlations in selection situations than in nonselection situations (Schilling et al., 2021). From this perspective, high stakes should shift

personality–GMA correlations upward for desirable traits, the opposite of compensation. For Conscientiousness, however, the selection-situation correlation was about three times larger in laboratory designs (ρ = .25) than in field studies (ρ = .08), although the field estimate remained positive (Schilling et al., 2021). Testing these competing predictions requires field data from genuine applicants.

The choice among these explanations also has practical consequences. Composite validity and composite subgroup differences are nonlinear functions of predictor intercorrelations (Sackett & Ellingson, 1997), so even a small shift in an input changes the resulting composite validity and subgroup-difference estimates. A negative GMA–Conscientiousness correlation, unlike a null one, creates a cooperative suppression situation, in which each predictor receives a larger regression weight than its zero-order validity implies, raising apparent composite validity while altering composite subgroup differences (Tzelgov & Henik, 1991). If a negative correlation is produced by compensatory faking, not by a true relation between the traits, the same mechanism that shifts the intercorrelation also degrades the criterion validity of the observed personality scores. Distinguishing these possibilities requires modeling the mechanism.

The Present Studies

Study 1 compared Big Five–GMA correlations between genuine applicant samples and lower stakes samples in the Stanek and Ones (2023c) database, then translated the estimates into decision consequences through a Monte Carlo simulation. Study 2 turned the simulation from a device for translating correlations into a direct test of the faking mechanism itself. Faking was assigned as a function of applicant traits, anchored to published trait–faking correlations. Study 1's meta-analytic estimates were used to compare competing published parameter sets and test targeted inflation against trait-general inflation. Because the theoretical perspectives make

competing predictions about the same Study 1 contrast, the focal tests are framed as research questions rather than hypotheses:

Research Question 1 (direction): Do applicant samples show a negative Conscientiousness–GMA correlation, as compensation predicts, or a positive correlation, as faking as skill predicts?

Research Question 2 (trait specificity): Is the applicant–incumbent difference trait specific, appearing for evaluative trait content but not for Openness, as a targeted mechanism predicts, or does it appear as attenuation toward zero across all five factors, as trait-general distortion predicts?

Two further exploratory research questions address constructs below the Big Five and study-level moderators:

Research Question 3: Do stakes-related shifts appear at the level of facets, aspects, and compound traits (constructs that blend multiple Big Five factors, such as Self-Esteem and Ambition; Stanek & Ones, 2023b), and if so, for which content?

Research Question 4: Are stakes-related shifts moderated by study characteristics codable in the database (country, publication era, publication type)?

The final aim is applied. The present research derives context-matched GMA–Big Five intercorrelation inputs and quantifies what context-mismatched inputs cost in composite validity, adverse-impact projection, and hiring decisions, using both closed-form calculation and Monte Carlo simulation.

Study 1: Stakes Moderation of Personality–GMA Relations

Method

Transparency and Openness

All inclusion criteria, data exclusions, and analytic decisions are reported below (Appelbaum et al., 2018). This study is a secondary analysis of the Stanek and Ones (2023c) Personality Traits and Cognitive Abilities Relations Database (https://doi.org/10.13020/7YS8-ET75), used under a CC BY-NC-ND 3.0 US license (https://creativecommons.org/licenses/by-nc-nd/3.0/us/). No new data were collected, and the database is not redistributed. All analysis and simulation code (Python, Version 3.14) and the aggregate tables and figures are available from the author until a public repository is posted; the database itself is not part of these materials. The analytic pipeline is fully scripted from the raw database to every table and figure. The study was not preregistered. The simulation studies are nonetheless reported against the ADEMP template of aims, data-generating mechanism, estimands, methods, and performance measures (Morris et al., 2019; Siepe et al., 2024). Research Questions 1 and 2 were specified before the moderator and simulation analyses were run; the facet and compound-trait scan (Research Question 3), the moderator analyses (Research Question 4), and all other analyses labeled exploratory were not planned in advance. A data transparency appendix follows the reference list.

Database and Inclusion Criteria

The Stanek and Ones (2023c) personality–ability relations database contains 60,690 correlations from primary studies conducted between 1925 and 2014 in more than 50 countries. Correlations were included when (a) the cognitive construct was *g* (general mental ability composites and *g*-loaded total scores under the database's Cattell–Horn–Carroll mapping) and (b) the personality construct was a global Big Five factor. These criteria retained 3,618 correlations.

Samples whose type was mixed, unreported, or outside the four stakes-classifiable categories (applicant, incumbent, student, community) could not be assigned a stakes group and were excluded from all analyses (289 correlations; 148 independent sample × trait effects), including the pooled low-stakes estimates. For the small number of samples whose correlations carried more than one sample-type label, the modal label was used; no sample mixed applicant with incumbent rows, and the single tie (resolved to the incumbent label) affects the incumbent Conscientiousness mean by less than .001. Construct-alignment reversals were applied per the database legend so that all correlations are signed toward the named constructs. For Research Question 3, the same criteria were applied to all personality constructs below the global Big Five (facets, aspects, and compound traits) with at least five applicant and five incumbent samples, which retained 12 constructs.

Assessment-Stakes Coding

Stakes were coded from the database's sample-type field. High stakes comprised applicant samples, that is, individuals assessed during genuine selection; all but one are personnel selection samples, and one involved competitive university-admission testing. Low stakes comprised employee/incumbent samples assessed for research purposes, student samples, and community samples. Incumbent samples served as the focal comparison group because incumbents are working adults assessed with the same kinds of instruments in employment settings; they differ from applicants chiefly in the stakes attached to the assessment, whereas student and community samples differ additionally in age, test content, and setting. Contrasts against all pooled low-stakes samples are also reported. Military samples mix entry screening with research administrations; they were retained as a separate category for sensitivity analyses and were not assigned to either group. The applicant designation is an operational classification,

not a judgment-based rating. A sample was coded high stakes when respondents completed the inventory while applying for a position or admission, a fact recorded in the database's sample-type field. The author verified all 26 applicant designations (117 correlation rows) against the database's sample-type code and, where available, the primary sources; none was reclassified.

Effect-Size Independence

Statistically dependent correlations (same construct pair within the same meta-analysis sample) were composited by averaging correlations and taking the median reported *N*, following the composite-score recommendations of Schmidt and Hunter (2015, Chapter 10). This step yielded 2,158 independent sample × trait correlations.

Meta-Analytic Procedures

Primary analyses used psychometric (bare-bones) meta-analysis with sample-size weighting (Schmidt & Hunter, 2015). For each trait × context cell, the *N*-weighted mean observed correlation ($\bar{r}$), its 95% confidence interval, the residual standard deviation after subtracting sampling-error variance (SD_{res}), and the 80% credibility interval were computed. Moderation was tested with subgroup moderator analyses (Schmidt & Hunter, 2015, Chapter 9): *z* contrasts on independent subgroup means using the standard errors of the bare-bones means, with each contrast (Δ) reported alongside its 95% confidence interval. Contrasts were computed from unrounded subgroup means, so a reported Δ can differ in the second decimal from the difference between the rounded means shown in the tables. To test moderation while adjusting for study-level covariates, weighted least squares meta-regressions of correlations on a high-stakes indicator were estimated with controls for study year, percentage male, and mean age, weighting by sample size with heteroscedasticity-robust standard errors (Steel & Kammeyer-Mueller, 2002). Moderators for Research Question 4 were coded from the database. Country was

coded US versus non-US, publication type was coded published versus unpublished, and publication era was coded by study year (a median split at 2005 for the within-applicant comparison; pre-1990, 1990–2004, and 2005–2013 bins for the low-stakes trend analyses).

For the applied aim, mean correlations were corrected for measurement error in both variables using constant artifact values (personality reliability = .80; GMA reliability = .85), consistent with artifact-distribution practice when study-level artifacts are unavailable (Schmidt & Hunter, 2015). No range-restriction correction was applied because applicant samples are assessed before selection occurs; the applicant pool, not a selected subset, is the relevant population for selection modeling.

Robustness and Bias Analyses

Four checks addressed the stability of the focal applicant estimates. First, all subgroup analyses were re-estimated with DerSimonian and Laird (1986) random-effects models on Fisher-*z* transformed correlations. Second, leave-one-out re-estimation quantified the influence of individual samples, following case-deletion influence diagnostics for meta-analysis (Viechtbauer & Cheung, 2010). Third, small-study and publication bias were assessed with Egger's regression test (Egger et al., 1997) and with PET-PEESE meta-regression adjustments (Stanley & Doucouliagos, 2014). Fourth, a sensitivity grid varied personality reliability over {.75, .80, .85} and GMA reliability over {.80, .85, .90}. Full results appear in the online supplement.

Selection-Outcome Modeling

Two models translated context-specific intercorrelations into selection outcomes for an equal-weight standardized composite of GMA and Conscientiousness under top-down selection. Monte Carlo simulation is the established approach for tracing selection-system consequences

that lack closed-form expressions (Sackett & Roth, 1996), including the effects of applicant faking on criterion-related validity and hiring decisions (Berry & Sackett, 2009; Converse et al., 2009; Komar et al., 2008). Simulation remains in active use in the current validity–diversity literature alongside closed-form matrix methods (De Corte et al., 2022; Song et al., 2017). Design and reporting are organized around the ADEMP framework of aims, data-generating mechanism, estimands, methods, and performance measures (Morris et al., 2019; Siepe et al., 2024). ADEMP was developed for evaluating statistical estimators, and this article adapts it to a simulation experiment about a substantive mechanism while retaining its central distinction among the estimand (the quantity a simulation is designed to learn), the estimator (the procedure that computes it), and the estimate (the number the procedure returns, which carries Monte Carlo error). In both studies the estimands are three selection outcomes defined against the honest counterfactual in the same applicant pool, namely the percentage of top-down hiring decisions that change, the proportional change in the mean true performance of those hired, and the adverse-impact ratio under each ranking; Study 2 adds a fourth estimand, the mean integrity of the applicants who gain and lose seats when hiring decisions change. The simulation procedure is the estimator, the tabled values are its estimates, and Monte Carlo standard errors accompany each simulation table. The data-generating mechanism is based on published empirical estimates, not arbitrary parameter grids.

Analytic model. Composite validity and composite Black–White *d* are closed-form functions of the intercorrelation (Sackett & Ellingson, 1997). The analytic model inserts each intercorrelation estimate into these formulas while holding all other inputs constant. Expected standardized job performance of selected applicants follows the classic selection-utility model (Naylor & Shine, 1965; Taylor & Russell, 1939), and adverse-impact ratios were computed

against the four-fifths convention (Equal Employment Opportunity Commission et al., 1978). Inputs were taken from published sources. Operational validities were .31 for GMA and .19 for Conscientiousness (Sackett et al., 2022). Black–White *d* was 0.79 for GMA (applicant-sample based; Roth et al., 2011, via Sackett et al., 2022) and −0.07 for Conscientiousness (Dahlke & Sackett, 2017, via Sackett et al., 2022; positive values indicate higher White means). The minority applicant-pool proportion was 1/6. Operational validities of this kind are corrected for range restriction and criterion unreliability but not for predictor unreliability. The intercorrelation inputs in the selection-outcome analyses (Figure 3; Table 4) are observed correlations. The reliability-corrected values in Table 3, Panel B, are reported for construct-level comparison, and each display labels which metric it uses. Intercorrelation inputs were the Berry et al. (2024) matrix value (+.03) and the present study's context-specific estimates (+.01 US applicants; −.07 pooled applicants; −.27 non-US applicants; see Results and Table 3). The subgroup parameters are US-derived, so the adverse-impact projections in the pooled and non-US conditions illustrate the mechanism under US demographic assumptions and do not describe any non-US jurisdiction.

Monte Carlo Simulation. The analytic model assumes criterion validities are invariant to context, an assumption compensatory faking violates. The simulation therefore modeled the mechanism. Honest scores (*g*, C) were drawn from a bivariate normal distribution with the incumbent-baseline correlation estimated here (US +.01; non-US +.05); true performance was generated to reproduce the Sackett et al. (2022) operational validities for honest scores. A randomly selected 40% of applicants faked, adding to observed Conscientiousness an inflation term with a mean component, a compensatory component proportional to −*g*, and idiosyncratic noise ($\sigma = 0.50$; the noise magnitude is not identified by the two fitting targets, so it was fixed a priori and varied from 0.25 to 1.00 in sensitivity runs). The 40% figure is the midpoint of the

30%–50% range from within-person applicant studies (Donovan et al., 2014; Griffith et al., 2007) and the upper bound of the 30% (±10%) evidence synthesis (Griffith & Converse, 2011); prevalences of 20%, 30%, and 50%, spanning the synthesis lower bound through the within-person upper bound, were run as sensitivity conditions. The prevalence figure denotes the proportion of applicants who fake at all. The within-person studies classify a faker as anyone whose applicant score exceeds a measurement-error interval on at least one scale (49.7% of applicants in Donovan et al., 2014, against single-scale rates of 14%–25%), and that any-scale quantity is what the model's binary faker indicator represents. The two free parameters (mean inflation; compensatory slope) were jointly solved so that each simulated applicant pool reproduced two empirical targets: the applicant–incumbent Conscientiousness mean shift of d = 0.45 (Birkeland et al., 2006) and the applicant Conscientiousness–GMA correlation estimated in this study for that context (US +.01; pooled −.07; non-US −.27). The three estimands (percentage of hires changed, true performance of hires, adverse-impact ratio) were evaluated against the honest counterfactual in the same simulated pool (n = 200,000 per condition). Primary results come from a single pool per condition. To quantify Monte Carlo error, the six primary conditions were replicated across 25 independent pools (seeds 2026–2050) with the inflation parameters re-solved in each. The tabled estimates differed from the replication means by at most 0.2 percentage points for the percentage of hires changed, 1.1 points for performance loss, and 0.03 for the adverse-impact ratio, and standard errors of the replication means were at most 0.06 points, 0.19 points, and 0.003, respectively.

Results

To verify the analytic pipeline, total-database estimates (all contexts pooled) were benchmarked against the published values from the same database (Stanek & Ones, 2023a) and

matched throughout; for example, the corrected Openness–GMA correlation is ρ = .26 in both (Supplemental Table S1).

Research Questions 1 and 2: Stakes Moderation of Big Five–GMA Correlations

Table 1 presents the meta-analytic estimates for applicant and incumbent samples and the applicant–incumbent contrasts; Figure 1 displays estimates for all five assessment contexts (complete estimates for student, community, and military samples appear in Supplemental Table S2). Figure 2 shows every Conscientiousness sample's observed correlation and 95% confidence interval by assessment context; forest plots for Neuroticism (Supplemental Figure S2), Openness (Supplemental Figure S3), Extraversion (Supplemental Figure S4), and Agreeableness (Supplemental Figure S5) appear in the supplemental materials. The Conscientiousness–GMA correlation reversed sign between incumbents ($\bar{r}$ = .03, k = 71, N = 18,242) and applicants ($\bar{r}$ = −.07, k = 20, N = 20,757), Δ = −.11, 95% CI [−.18, −.03], z = −2.78, p = .005, answering Research Question 1 and supporting the compensatory faking perspective. Neuroticism, Extraversion, and Agreeableness showed no applicant–incumbent differences (all $|\Delta| < .03$, $p \geq .29$), and Openness was equivalent across applicants and incumbents (.14 vs. .15, Δ = .00, 95% CI [−.04, .04]), answering Research Question 2 in favor of trait specificity and against uniform attenuation. Against all pooled low-stakes samples, the Conscientiousness contrast was directionally identical but nonsignificant (Δ = −.07, p = .063), and small Openness, Neuroticism, and Agreeableness contrasts reached significance ($|\Delta|$ = .04–.05; Supplemental Table S2). The trait-specific pattern was clearest in the incumbent contrast. Applicant heterogeneity was largest for Conscientiousness (SD_{res} = .16 vs. ≤ .10 for the other traits), with an 80% credibility interval of [−.28, +.13]; individual applicant settings plausibly range from strongly negative to modestly positive.

DerSimonian–Laird random-effects estimates were −.10, 95% CI [−.19, −.02] for applicants and +.03 [−.01, .06] for incumbents; the meta-regression with year, sex, and age controls (59 samples with complete covariates) yielded a directionally consistent but nonsignificant high-stakes coefficient ($b_{\text{high-stakes}} = -.16$, $p = .07$; an unweighted specification gave $b = -.10$, $p = .27$, and a Fisher-z weighted specification agreed with the primary estimate); leave-one-out re-estimation left the applicant mean negative with any single sample omitted (range −.14 to −.04); Egger's test showed no funnel asymmetry ($p = .41$); PET and PEESE adjusted estimates remained negative (−.04, −.08); and corrected estimates varied by less than .02 across the reliability grid (Supplemental Table S3). Publication-bias diagnostics for the applicant pools of all five traits appear in Supplemental Table S4.

Research Question 3: Facet, Aspect, and Compound-Trait Contrasts

Table 2 presents applicant–incumbent contrasts for the 12 facets, aspects, and compound traits meeting the sample-size criterion. Three findings stand out. First, Ambition, a compound trait blending conscientious achievement striving with extraverted surgency and the construct most directly expressing the motive to get ahead (Hogan & Holland, 2003; Judge & Kammeyer-Mueller, 2012), replicated the global Conscientiousness reversal at nearly identical magnitude ($\Delta = -.16$, 95% CI [−.27, −.05], $p = .005$). Second, the narrow facets and aspects (Achievement, Dependability, Orderliness, Dominance, Sociability, Intellect, Depression, Uneven Temper) and the higher-order Factor Alpha showed no stakes-related shifts (all $|\Delta| \leq .05$; the smallest p was .079, for Sociability). Third, Self-Esteem and Trust shifted positively under high stakes (both $\Delta = +.17$, $p < .001$), the direction predicted by faking as skill. These contrasts are exploratory and are based on 5–9 applicant samples per construct.

Research Question 4: Moderators and Boundary Conditions

Of the codable moderators (country, publication era, publication type), only country was a significant moderator (Table 3, Panel A). The applicant–incumbent contrast for Conscientiousness was significant only in non-US samples (applicant $\bar{r} = -.27$, $k = 10$, $N = 6{,}050$ vs. incumbent +.05, $k = 20$, $N = 8{,}577$; $\Delta = -.33$, 95% CI [−.42, −.24], $z = -7.08$, $p < .001$), predominantly UK and Australia/New Zealand selection settings using British occupational inventories. Samples using the same UK-developed occupational inventory family contributed a large portion of the non-US applicant data (78% of the non-US applicant *N*) and may have a large influence on the non-US estimate; Supplemental Figure S6 displays these samples individually. In these samples the cognitive measure is the General Reasoning Test's Verbal Reasoning scale and the personality measure is a higher-order factor from the same vendor (the 15FQ/15FQ+ Control factor or the Occupational Personality Profile Detail-Conscious–Flexible scale, the latter keyed toward flexibility in the source instrument and reverse-scored toward Conscientiousness in the database, a direction verified against the instrument's technical documentation). The US subgroup means did not differ ($\Delta = -.01$, 95% CI [−.07, .06]), although individual US applicant samples ranged from −.15 to +.14 (Supplemental Figure S6); the regional difference is one of subgroup means, not an absence of negative correlations among US samples. Because non-US applicants differ from non-US incumbents, the contrast is not an artifact of comparing regions with each other. Even so, applicant and incumbent samples can differ in more than assessment stakes. Region is also confounded with instrument family and national selection practices in these data. Within the applicant pool, published and unpublished sources did not differ for Conscientiousness (−.09 vs. −.07, $p = .76$), and estimates did not differ significantly by publication era (−.05 through 2005 vs. −.11 after, $p = .43$). In the low-stakes

pool, the Openness–GMA correlation declined from $\bar{r}$ = .27 in pre-1990 studies to .17 in 2005–2013 studies (Supplemental Table S5).

Selection-Outcome Analyses

Table 3, Panel B presents observed and reliability-corrected GMA–Big Five correlations for high-stakes, low-stakes, and total-database estimates. Given the regional boundary, the high-stakes Conscientiousness input splits into approximately +.01 for US selection contexts and −.27 for the non-US contexts represented here; the pooled applicant value (−.09 corrected) is a weighted blend that describes neither region well.

In the analytic model, moving from the corrected total-database input (ρ_{12} = +.01) to the corrected pooled applicant input (−.09) raised optimal regression-weighted composite validity from R = .362 to .379 and equal-weight validity from .352 to .371, while composite d rose from 0.507 to 0.534 (Supplemental Table S6; Supplemental Figure S1 plots both quantities across the full range of GMA weights). At a .10 selection ratio, expected hire performance was 0.61, 0.62, 0.65, and 0.73 *SD*, and the adverse-impact ratio was 0.38, 0.38, 0.36, and 0.31, for r_{12} = +.03 (the Berry et al., 2024, matrix value) and the observed applicant estimates from this study (+.01 US, −.07 pooled, −.27 non-US), respectively (Figure 3, left and center panels).

Table 4 presents the Monte Carlo simulation results. The fitted parameters recovered the empirical targets in all conditions (achieved mean shifts d = 0.45–0.49; achieved correlations within .011 of targets). First, faking changed many hiring decisions even where it barely moved the intercorrelation. In the US condition, in which faking shifts means (d = 0.45) but is essentially unrelated to g (compensatory slope = 0.01), 22%–36% of top-down hires differed from the honest counterfactual and mean true performance of hires was 8%–10% lower, because heterogeneous faking reorders applicants near the cutoff. Second, the analytic model and the

simulation disagreed about validity. Inserting the high-stakes intercorrelation into standard formulas while holding validities fixed raised apparent composite validity, whereas the mechanism that produces that intercorrelation lowered realized hire performance by 8%–19%, because faking degrades the criterion validity of observed Conscientiousness scores. Third, compensatory faking was mildly diversity positive. In the non-US condition, in which inflation concentrates among lower-*g* applicants, the adverse-impact ratio improved from 0.37 to 0.52 at a .10 selection ratio; in the US condition it was essentially unchanged (0.40 to 0.39). Sensitivity runs varying faking noise (σ = 0.25–1.00, all three conditions) scaled all effects without changing any direction (Supplemental Table S7). Varying faking prevalence likewise changed no direction. Because the fitted parameters must reproduce the same pool-level evidence at any prevalence, lower prevalence concentrates larger inflation in fewer applicants, and outcomes worsen. Losses ran 12%–33% at 30% prevalence against 7%–15% at 50%. At 20%, the lower bound of the Griffith and Converse (2011) synthesis, the model demands per-faker mean inflation of 3.0–4.8 *SD* (more than bounded response scales permit), so that condition marks an upper bound on harm rather than a realistic scenario (Supplemental Table S9). The 40% midpoint reported above is accordingly not the worst case the published prevalence evidence allows.

Figure 4 traces the modeled mechanism for the most extreme condition (non-US condition, .10 selection ratio) in three steps: the fitted compensatory inflation function that turns the pool correlation negative (Panel A), the rank-order change that inflation produces at the selection cutoff (Panel B), and the performance consequences for the seats that change hands, expressed in both criterion *SD* units and illustrative dollar values (Panel C). Applicants who gained a seat through faking underperformed the applicants they displaced by 0.33 *SD* (Panel C:

0.51 vs. 0.19 *SD*; an illustrative $9,100 per swapped hire per year under the convention that SD_y equals 40% of salary; Schmidt & Hunter, 1983), even though the aggregate loss across all hires was a more modest 0.10 *SD* in the figure's pool (0.09 *SD* in the corresponding Table 4 condition).

Study 2: Trait-Driven Faking and Hiring Outcomes

Study 1's Monte Carlo simulation assumed that the 40% of applicants who fake were selected at random. The individual-differences literature, however, suggests otherwise. Within-person designs, in which the same people complete a personality inventory under high and under lower stakes, have documented the prevalence, magnitude, and consequences of faking by genuine applicants (Ellingson et al., 2007; Griffith et al., 2007; Peterson et al., 2011). Only one study of genuine job applicants to date has measured hypothesized traits and ability as predictors of that inflation (Holtrop et al., 2021). Specifically, cognitive ability correlated −.19 with score elevation (higher-ability applicants faked *less*), whereas honesty-humility and Conscientiousness were unrelated to elevation. An incentivized simulation with real stakes found nearly the opposite pattern. Cognitive ability was *positively* related to faking (partial r = .14 controlling for gender, p = .051), and honesty-humility, unexpectedly, correlated +.21 with faking (Dunlop et al., 2022). Among genuine applicants to a teacher-education program, intelligence likewise weakly and positively predicted inflation of Conscientiousness and Emotional Stability (Weißenbacher et al., 2025), so the direction of the ability–faking relation may depend on the selection setting as well as the design. This divergence mirrors the contrast between Study 1's applicant estimates and the laboratory-based selection-context correlations reported by Schilling et al. (2021). Laboratory studies appear to assess the *ability* to fake as instructed, whereas field studies appear to assess the *need* to fake (Schilling et al., 2021).

Who fakes is important for two reasons that the random-faker model cannot address. First, if the published trait–faking correlations differ by design type, then the competing parameter sets can be tested against the meta-analytic applicant estimates from Study 1. A parameterized model of who fakes is tenable only if the simulated pool of faking applicants can reproduce the observed applicant–incumbent shifts and correlations. Second, if applicants who fake differ systematically on traits the selection system does not measure (integrity above all), then faking changes not only how many hiring decisions change but which applicants gain seats.

Study 2 therefore extended the Study 1 simulation in three steps. First, whether an applicant faked was made a function of applicant traits, with the parameters *solved* to reproduce published trait–faking correlations, not assumed. Second, competing published parameter sets (field vs. laboratory) were tested against the Study 1 estimates. Third, the inflation mechanism itself was tested in a way Study 1 could not. Targeted inflation of job-relevant content was contrasted against inflation of *all* scales in proportion to their meta-analytic correlations with social desirability scales (Ones et al., 1996), hereafter desirability-proportional inflation. The comparison drew additional evidence from the meta-analytic finding that applicant–incumbent score elevations concentrate on Conscientiousness and Emotional Stability while the Agreeableness elevation is small and nonsignificant (Birkeland et al., 2006).

Method

The simulation is reported in the ADEMP structure introduced in Study 1 (Morris et al., 2019; Siepe et al., 2024). The aims are the three extensions stated above. The latent trait model, the logistic function governing who fakes, and the two inflation mechanisms described below jointly constitute the data-generating mechanism. The estimands add the integrity composition of changed hires (mean honesty-humility of the applicants who gain seats under faking and of the

applicants they displace) to the three Study 1 quantities. The methods under comparison are competing parameterizations of the faking mechanism (four anchor sets, two inflation mechanisms, and three functional forms). These are not competing statistical estimators. The performance measures are the minimized weighted distance between achieved and target values, which measures whether a parameterization can reproduce the meta-analytic evidence, and Monte Carlo standard errors from replicated pools.

Latent Trait Model

Each simulated applicant received six latent traits drawn from a multivariate normal distribution: GMA (*g*), Conscientiousness, Emotional Stability, Agreeableness, honesty-humility/integrity, and a confidence/self-esteem compound (hereafter the confidence compound), included so the pool can reproduce the Self-Esteem–GMA shift observed in Study 1. The *g*–Conscientiousness baseline used Study 1's incumbent estimates (US +.01, pooled +.03, non-US +.05). The remaining correlations were fixed to published values: integrity–GMA = .00 (Ones, 1993; Anglim et al., 2022, report .02 for honesty-humility); honesty-humility correlations with Conscientiousness, Emotional Stability, and Agreeableness taken from one of two meta-analytic sources, because the published estimates differ by instrument family. The HEXACO honesty-humility values are .25, .14, and .50 (Howard & Van Zandt, 2020; corrected ρ; k = 71, 68, and 79). The overt integrity-test values are .39, .28, and .34 (Sackett & Wanek, 1996, Table 3, as cited in Lee et al., 2005; corrected for unreliability; observed r = .26, .18, and .23). The two sources yield different integrity gaps and the Results report both, with the HEXACO values tabled as the primary specification; Big Five intercorrelations from van der Linden et al. (2010; corrected ρ = .43, .43, .36 for Conscientiousness–Emotional Stability, Conscientiousness–Agreeableness, and Emotional Stability–Agreeableness); and self-esteem–GMA = .01, this

study's incumbent estimate. True job performance reproduced operational validities of .31 (GMA), .19 (Conscientiousness; Sackett et al., 2022), and .18 for integrity (the upper corrected estimate of Van Iddekinge et al., 2012; sensitivity runs used .15 and .41, the bounds of that literature, and results were insensitive). Subgroup differences and selection followed the Study 1 simulation design: composite of *g* and observed Conscientiousness, top-down selection at ratios of .10 and .30, n = 200,000 per condition.

Who Fakes: Anchored, Not Assumed

Whether an applicant faked was governed by a logistic function of *g*, Conscientiousness, and honesty-humility. The slopes were not free parameters; they were solved numerically so that the simulated pool reproduced target point-biserial correlations between each trait and the faking indicator, along with the 40% prevalence (Donovan et al., 2014; Griffith et al., 2007). Four anchor sets were examined (Table 5): a *field* set using the Holtrop et al. (2021) point estimates (−.19, +.17, −.04 for *g*, Conscientiousness, and honesty-humility); a *field-conservative* set zeroing that study's two nonsignificant estimates (−.19, 0, 0); a *laboratory* set from Dunlop et al. (2022; +.14, −.15, +.21, with the Conscientiousness value taken from the interview-faking literature's range); and a laboratory variant reversing the honesty-humility sign to its classically expected direction.

Inflation Mechanisms: Targeted Versus Trait-General

For applicants who faked, two competing models of *what* gets inflated were implemented on the same pools. Under **targeted inflation**, fakers inflated only the Conscientiousness, Emotional Stability, and self-esteem scales (the job-relevant and confidence-toned content), with a mean component per scale, a compensatory component proportional to the applicant's honest deficit, and a skill component proportional to *g*. Under **desirability-proportional inflation**,

fakers inflated *all* scales in proportion to each trait's meta-analytic correlation with social desirability scales (Ones et al., 1996), the formal statement of the trait-general distortion perspective. Desirability-proportional inflation has a testable implication that targeted inflation lacks. Because Agreeableness correlates with social desirability scales, applicant Agreeableness scores must be elevated nearly as much as Conscientiousness scores under this mechanism, but meta-analytic evidence suggests that elevation is nonsignificant (d = 0.16, 95% CI [−0.01, 0.32], vs. d = 0.45 for Conscientiousness; Birkeland et al., 2006).

Parameter Estimation and Performance Measures

Free inflation parameters were fit by weighted least squares so that each simulated applicant pool reproduced six empirical targets per context: the applicant–incumbent mean shifts for Conscientiousness (d = 0.45), Emotional Stability (d = 0.44), and Agreeableness (d = 0.16; Birkeland et al., 2006); the applicant Conscientiousness–GMA correlation from Study 1 (US +.01, pooled −.07, non-US −.27); the Self-Esteem–GMA applicant–incumbent difference from Study 1 (Δ = +.17), computed against the same incumbent comparison group as the other contrasts; and an applicant/honest standard-deviation ratio of 0.86, the Conscientiousness U ratio from the within-subjects applicant-faking meta-analysis (Hu & Connelly, 2021; k = 18, N = 3,346).

Each target was weighted by its precision. The three mean-shift targets received the inverse squared standard errors recovered from their meta-analytic confidence intervals. The variance-ratio target instead received a weight based on its between-study heterogeneity (SD = 0.17), because the fit matches a single applicant pool and observed pools vary widely (80% credibility interval [0.64, 1.08]).

The minimized weighted distance between achieved and target values served as the model-comparison statistic. It measures whether *any* setting of the inflation parameters allows a given inflation mechanism to reproduce the six targets. An inflation mechanism whose best-fitting parameters still miss the targets is contradicted by the meta-analytic evidence; its minimized distance is reported in Table 5 alongside the others and is not dropped.

Robustness was assessed in several ways. Monte Carlo error was quantified across 25 replications with independent pools (Morris et al., 2019). The Conscientiousness–faking anchor was varied in small steps across its plausible range, with all parameters refit at each step, to locate the value beyond which the targets could no longer be reproduced. Two functional-form relaxations (inflation censored at zero; separate skill slopes per scale) were refit against the same six targets to test whether conclusions depend on the linear inflation form. Faking prevalence was varied across the published 30%–50% range. The variance-ratio target was varied from 0.64 to 1.00, and the two provisional correlations involving the confidence compound (with Conscientiousness, .30, and with integrity, .20) were varied ±.10 in a full grid with refitting. Last, the model-implied Emotional Stability–GMA applicant shift, a quantity the fit never used, was compared with Study 1's independent estimate as a falsification check.

Results

Which Published Faking Parameters Fit the Applicant-Pool Evidence?

Table 5 reports how closely each anchor set reproduced the six meta-analytic targets. All targeted-inflation distances include a fixed component of approximately 3.5 from the Agreeableness shift target, which targeted inflation leaves at zero by construction; because that component is constant, it does not affect comparisons among anchor sets. The field set's +.17 Conscientiousness–faking anchor, a nonsignificant estimate from $n = 128$, fit the US targets

worst (weighted distance 8.2, against 3.8 for the best-fitting set, driven by inflated observed-score variance). Simulated pools in which more conscientious applicants fake more reproduced the meta-analytic estimates poorly. The one-parameter sensitivity analysis, a heuristic screen rather than a formal inference procedure, located the boundary. The US targets accept Conscientiousness–faking correlations up to approximately +.14 and reject values above it, while the pooled and non-US targets accept the entire range examined (through +.20), leaving the +.17 anchor tenable outside the US condition. The field-conservative and laboratory sets fit better (distances 3.8–6.6), and the target set could not distinguish the *g* and honesty-humility slopes; those parameters depend on the primary studies alone. The field-conservative set was designated primary because its *g* slope (−.19) is the only estimate obtained from genuine applicants. Selection outcomes were computed for every anchor set in every condition under a uniform reporting rule (all cells reported; Supplemental Table S11). The laboratory set's outcomes were unremarkable in the US and pooled conditions (7%–12% of hire performance lost), but in the non-US condition the set implied that 39%–48% of hire performance would be lost, damage far outside the range the faking-outcomes literature supports. This is consistent with the published pattern that laboratory faking effects exceed those observed in operational selection (Birkeland et al., 2006; Schilling et al., 2021).

Targeted Versus Trait-General Inflation

The desirability-proportional mechanism fit worse than targeted inflation in every context and under every anchor set (Table 5, right columns): weighted distances of 13.8–15.0 (US), 25.5–27.4 (pooled), and 67.7–73.2 (non-US), against 3.8–8.2 for targeted inflation. Two targets separate the mechanisms. First, proportional inflation degrades the Conscientiousness shift (achieved d = 0.31–0.37 vs. the observed 0.45) because the optimizer must spread inflation

across all scales and cannot concentrate it on Conscientiousness. Second, the mechanism cannot reproduce the positive Self-Esteem–GMA shift. It reversed the sign in the non-US condition (−.18 achieved vs. +.17 observed), drove the shift to approximately zero in the pooled condition, and reached less than a third of the target in the US condition (+.05). The Agreeableness target itself does not separate the mechanisms cleanly: proportional inflation overshoots it (achieved d = 0.29–0.31 vs. 0.16) while targeted inflation undershoots it (0 by construction), each missing by a comparable amount relative to the target's standard error. The relative rejection held when the Agreeableness–social-desirability correlation was halved or re-estimated, although halving narrows the US gap (10.7 vs. 6.2). Study 1 rejected trait-general distortion through the trait specificity of the moderation pattern (Research Question 2). Study 2 rejected it by modeling the mechanism. No parameterization of desirability-proportional inflation reproduced the meta-analytic applicant pool as well as targeted inflation did, and the shortfall concentrated on the targets that define the compensatory pattern.

A Lower Bound on Compensatory Faking

When inflation was constrained to be non-negative, so that no faker could accidentally lower their own score, the non-US applicant correlation of −.27 became unreachable. The most extreme correlation producible by within-person compensatory inflation was approximately −.26. Unconstrained fits reached −.27 only by assigning negative inflation to a tail of high-standing fakers, an artifact of the linear functional form. Within-person compensation therefore has a lower bound near −.26, and the remaining distance to the observed non-US value implicates additional mechanisms, plausibly differences in who enters non-US applicant pools. This converges with Study 1's conclusion that the regional boundary reflects confounded study characteristics, not a single distortion process.

Selection Outcomes: Who Gains Seats and What It Costs

Table 6 reports selection outcomes under the primary specification. Two results extend Study 1. The first concerns the integrity composition of changed hires. The size of this effect depends on which meta-analytic integrity–personality correlations are adopted, so Table 6 reports the integrity gap under both sources described in the Method. Under the HEXACO correlations (Howard & Van Zandt, 2020), simulated applicants hired only because of modeled faking averaged 0.16–0.45 *SD* lower honesty-humility than the simulated applicants they displaced under the linear inflation form. Under the overt integrity-test correlations (Sackett & Wanek, 1996, as cited in Lee et al., 2005), the same pools produced gaps of 0.29–0.70 *SD*. In both cases the largest gaps appeared in the non-US condition. Under the ceiling form that the variance-ratio target favors in the US and pooled conditions (Supplemental Table S10), those gaps widen to 0.33–0.49 *SD* (HEXACO) and 0.52–0.75 *SD* (overt tests). The two sources differ because the gap is transmitted almost entirely through the Conscientiousness–integrity correlation (.25 vs. .39); the choice left the percentage of hires changed, performance loss, adverse-impact ratios, and fit distances unchanged beyond Monte Carlo error (Table 6 note). Under Study 1's random-faker benchmark on identical pools, the corresponding faked-in hires showed no integrity deficit under either source; their mean honesty-humility ranged from 0.00 to +0.28 *SD* (HEXACO) and from −0.01 to +0.43 *SD* (overt tests) across conditions and selection ratios, at or above the pool average. Random faking swaps seats between roughly equivalent people, whereas trait-driven faking systematically replaces higher-integrity hires with lower-integrity ones. Because integrity independently predicts performance and counterproductive behavior (Ones et al., 1993; Van Iddekinge et al., 2012), this composition effect is a real cost that

no adverse-impact audit would detect; adverse-impact ratios were essentially unchanged by trait-driven faking in every condition (Table 6).

The second result concerns aggregate performance loss. The variance-ratio target helps distinguish among functional forms of inflation, on which the aggregate loss estimates depend. Under the linear-inflation fit, mean hire performance losses were 7.9%–10.4% (US and pooled) and 9.8%–17.9% (non-US). The two functional-form relaxations (inflation censored at zero and separate skill slopes per scale), refit against all six empirical targets, fit better than the linear form in the US and pooled conditions (weighted distances 0.6–0.8 vs. 1.4–2.7 above the fixed Agreeableness component) and agree with each other on losses of roughly 13%–18% there (Supplemental Table S10). The non-US condition favors the linear form, and its losses are comparable across admissible forms (10%–20%). US and pooled aggregate losses are accordingly reported as 8%–18%, with the variance evidence favoring the upper half of that range. Monte Carlo error was negligible throughout. Across 25 replications with independent pools and all parameters re-solved in each, standard errors of the replication means were at most 0.07 percentage points for the percentage of hires changed, 0.19 points for performance loss, 0.002 for adverse-impact ratios, and 0.004 for the integrity means, and the tabled estimates differed from the replication means by no more than 0.5 points, 0.7 points, 0.02, and 0.02, respectively.

Robustness and the Limits of Identification

The remaining robustness results bound the claims. The integrity-validity input (.15 vs. .41) was immaterial. The shared-skill restriction (one faking-skill coefficient across scales) was rejected in the US and pooled conditions, where freeing it cut the weighted distance above the fixed Agreeableness component from 2.7 to 0.8 and from 1.4 to 0.6, respectively, but supported

in the non-US condition (1.37 vs. 1.38). The freed form is one of the two relaxations underlying the upper half of the loss range above. Varying the variance-ratio target across its credibility interval (0.64 to 1.00) changed aggregate losses by less than three percentage points and did not change which mechanisms or anchor sets were favored; lower targets only strengthen the case against the +.17 Conscientiousness–faking anchor. The two provisional correlations involving the confidence compound were varied ±.10 in a full nine-cell grid per condition with complete refitting; weighted distances moved by less than 0.2, performance loss remained positive and the integrity gap negative in all 27 cells under both integrity–personality sources, and adverse-impact ratios changed by no more than 0.04 in any cell. Varying prevalence from 20%, the lower bound of the Griffith and Converse (2011) evidence synthesis, to 50% also left every direction unchanged and, as in Study 1, produced larger losses at lower prevalence in all but one cell (non-US, selection ratio .10, where the 40% and 50% losses differ by 0.4 points, within Monte Carlo error), though far more gradually than the random-faker model, because the six-target fit constrains how much inflation each faker can add (Supplemental Table S9). The *g* and honesty-humility slopes are pinned by primary studies, not by the empirical targets, and the targeted mechanism leaves the Agreeableness shift at zero by construction, taking a fixed penalty on that target instead of fitting it; neither mechanism reproduces the observed .16, and the mechanism comparison therefore rests on the Conscientiousness-shift and Self-Esteem–GMA targets. These limits are stated because they identify what future data can add. Within-person applicant studies that measure integrity directly would convert the model's central remaining assumption into an empirical target.

A final check exposed the targeted mechanism to falsification on a quantity it was never fit to. Because the same need and skill components that drive Conscientiousness inflation also

drive Emotional Stability inflation under the shared-slope form, the fitted model implies an applicant shift in the Emotional Stability–GMA correlation. Study 1 measured that shift independently. The Neuroticism applicant–incumbent contrast of −.01, reversed to the Emotional Stability scale, gives an observed shift of +.013, 95% CI [−.029, .055]. The model-implied shift fell inside that interval in the US condition (−.026) but outside it in the pooled (−.101) and non-US (−.279) conditions, and the result was the same under all three functional forms. Where compensatory pressure is strong, the mechanism as specified overpredicts compensatory distortion of Emotional Stability; the data are consistent with Emotional Stability elevation that is largely a mean shift without the ability-linked component the shared-slope form imposes. The mechanism comparison and the integrity-composition results do not turn on that component, but the failed prediction bounds the mechanism's generality and identifies the equation that within-person applicant data should revise first.

General Discussion

Personality–GMA relations estimated in research administrations do not hold in every operational selection setting. In Study 1, assessment stakes moderated the Conscientiousness–GMA correlation, reversing its sign among applicants, while leaving the other Big Five relations unchanged. These results support the compensatory faking perspective over faking as skill at the Big Five level (Research Question 1), and its trait specificity (Research Question 2) is inconsistent with trait-general distortion. The exploratory analyses qualified this conclusion in two directions. Beneath the Big Five, the reversal reappeared for Ambition and was absent for narrow facets, while the contrasts for confidence-related compounds ran in the opposite direction. Across regions, the mean reversal appeared only in non-US selection settings. Study 2 then compared each inflation mechanism with the meta-analytic evidence. Desirability-

proportional inflation could not reproduce the applicant pool under any parameterization. Published trait–faking estimates from laboratory paradigms reproduced the empirical targets only at the cost of implausibly large predicted losses. Under the trait-driven specifications that fit the targets, applicants who gained seats through faking were lower in integrity than those they displaced, and aggregate statistics did not detect that difference.

Interpretation and Theoretical Implications

Compensation (Ellingson & McFarland, 2011; Goffin & Boyd, 2009) and faking as skill (Kleinmann et al., 2011; Marcus, 2009; Schilling et al., 2021) have been treated as rival explanations of a single phenomenon. The construct-specific findings indicate that they operate simultaneously on different content. Broad claims of work competence (global Conscientiousness, Ambition) attracted compensatory inflation from applicants who could not compete on the ability component. Confidence-toned content (Self-Esteem, Trust) tracked the self-assurance that covaries with ability, in the direction reported for predominantly laboratory-based selection samples (Schilling et al., 2021). Narrow facet content was undisturbed. This reconciles the apparent conflict between the positive laboratory selection-context correlations (Schilling et al., 2021) and the negative applicant shift documented here for Conscientiousness in field data. The two literatures have been measuring different distortion processes operating on different content. No single mechanism can reproduce both sets of findings.

Trait-general distortion fails in both studies. In Study 1 the moderation was trait specific, and in Study 2 no desirability-proportional parameterization reproduces the applicant-pool estimates. Compensation, meanwhile, has a quantitative limit. Within-person inflation, however parameterized, cannot push the applicant Conscientiousness–GMA correlation below approximately −.26, so the non-US value of −.27 must partly reflect who enters those applicant

pools, not only how they respond. The evidence on who fakes also favors the field estimates over the laboratory estimates. Parameters in which more capable or more conscientious applicants fake more, which laboratory paradigms produce, either fit the applicant-pool targets poorly or implied damage far outside the range the outcome literature supports. One prediction the fit never used was not supported. The fitted mechanism implies a negative Emotional Stability–GMA shift among applicants in the pooled and non-US conditions, where Study 1 observed none, indicating that Emotional Stability elevation involves less ability-linked compensation than the model's shared-slope form imposes.

The regional boundary limits generalization in both directions. The non-US contrast holds within region, but US operational selection showed no Conscientiousness–GMA reversal in these data. Candidate explanations (instrument families, national differences in selection practice, job-type composition) are confounded here and separable only with primary studies that cross instruments with regions. The Study 2 lower bound adds pool composition to that list of candidates and quantifies the minimum contribution it must make.

Pool composition is the strongest rival explanation to response distortion. Applicant pools are shaped by self-selection, as individuals gravitate toward jobs that match their standing (Roth et al., 2001), so applicant and incumbent samples can differ in who is present, not only in how those present respond. Self-selection alone, however, does not predict the trait-specific pattern observed here, in which the Conscientiousness–GMA correlation differs between applicant and incumbent samples while the Openness–GMA correlation does not, and it does not predict the positive Self-Esteem and Trust shifts. The Study 2 analysis bounds what each process can contribute. Within-person inflation can account for applicant correlations down to approximately −.26; differences in who enters the non-US applicant pools plausibly account for the remainder.

External evidence narrows the boundary further. Schilling et al.'s (2021) supporting materials list six operational applicant datasets that they excluded because the sample sizes, 19,365 to over two million, would have dominated their averages. The Conscientiousness–GMA correlations in those datasets run from +.02 to +.18. One of the six, a French applicant sample of roughly 20,000, is in the Stanek–Ones database but is classified there as measuring fluid/inductive reasoning rather than *g* and so falls outside the present inclusion criteria; the remaining five do not appear in the database, and the two applicant pools share only four first authors, so the sources are largely independent. Supplemental Table S8 reports the present applicant estimates with those datasets appended. The pooled Conscientiousness estimate moves from −.07 to +.06, the US estimate from +.01 to +.07, and the non-US estimate from −.27 to +.02, the last driven entirely by the single French sample, whose cognitive measure would not meet the present *g* criterion. The negative applicant correlation is a property of the UK and Australia/New Zealand occupational-inventory settings, not of high-stakes assessment in general, and operational US testing programs, including post-2013 unproctored datasets absent from the present database, produce small positive values. The narrowing strengthens the case for context-matched inputs, since a single applicant value would err in opposite directions across these settings, and it makes a combined analysis of the two databases the clearest next step.

Practical Implications

For users of meta-analytic matrices (Berry et al., 2024; Roth et al., 2011; Sackett et al., 2022), there is no single GMA–Conscientiousness correlation. The matrix value should match the setting being modeled: approximately +.01 for US high-stakes selection, −.27 for the non-US settings represented here, which are dominated by UK and Australia/New Zealand occupational inventories, with the incumbent value (+.03) appropriate for research administrations.

Correlations of this size may look trivial. They are not effect sizes to be judged against conventional benchmarks but inputs that enter composite validity and subgroup-difference formulas nonlinearly and whose sign determines the direction of suppression effects.

The Monte Carlo simulation restates the point in terms of hiring decisions. Under faking parameters fit to the empirical targets, 22%–36% of top-down hiring decisions differed from what honest responding would have produced across Study 1's conditions, with mean hire performance 8%–19% lower; even in the US condition, where the intercorrelation barely moves, 22%–36% of hires changed and performance losses ran 8%–10%. The correlation shift marks systematic, ability-linked distortion. It does not measure the total cost of distortion. Selection researchers may accordingly wish to treat high-stakes intercorrelation shifts as evidence of a distortion process that also affects validity, not as interchangeable matrix values. Where the process is compensatory, it has one offsetting property, a partial reduction of GMA-driven adverse impact, which organizations should weigh explicitly.

Study 2 adds a cost that no standard audit detects. In the simulations, when who fakes follows the field evidence, the applicants who gain seats through faking are systematically lower in integrity than those they displace, by roughly 0.2 to 0.5 standard deviations under the HEXACO honesty-humility correlations and 0.3 to 0.8 under the overt integrity-test correlations across the admissible inflation forms, while adverse-impact ratios barely move. An organization monitoring validity coefficients and four-fifths compliance would see nothing. The change is in who is hired, and its costs arrive later, through the counterproductive-behavior pathway that integrity predicts (Ones et al., 1993). Emerging audit requirements for algorithmic hiring tools rely on statistics that miss this cost. New York City's Local Law 144, for example, mandates annual bias audits built on selection-rate impact ratios (Local Law No. 144, 2021), which the

present simulations show remain essentially undisturbed while the integrity composition of hires degrades. This argues for faking countermeasures (verification warnings, forced-choice formats) even in contexts where aggregate psychometrics look undisturbed, and for measuring integrity directly instead of inferring it from the personality composite.

Limitations and Future Directions

Each limitation below is stated with its consequence for the conclusions. Stakes were coded from sample type, not measured motivation, so misclassified samples would blur, not manufacture, the applicant–incumbent contrast; the completed verification of all 26 applicant designations, which reclassified none, limits this concern. Applicant *k* was modest (11–21 per trait; 5–10 per region or compound), so the regional and compound estimates have wide intervals and should not be treated as precise point values. The database ends at 2014, which predates widespread unproctored internet testing; if unproctored administration changes faking dynamics, the present inputs may understate current distortion. Region was confounded with instrument family and selection practices, so the non-US concentration cannot be attributed to culture, measures, or practices individually. More generally, stakes were not randomly assigned. Applicant and incumbent samples can differ in composition, instrumentation, and selection history, so the moderation results identify context differences in correlations, not the causal effect of stakes, and the mechanism language throughout reflects model assumptions evaluated against those correlations, not established causation. The applicant pool contained no forced-choice instruments, so faking-resistance predictions were untestable (Speer et al., 2023). Reliability corrections used constant artifact values, not the Stanek–Ones artifact distributions (Stanek & Ones, 2023b), though the sensitivity grid indicates corrected values are insensitive to plausible alternatives. The simulation simplified faking as linear-in-*g* inflation with independent

noise; within-subjects meta-analytic evidence indicates that rank-order change among actual applicants is smaller than laboratory designs suggest (Hu & Connelly, 2021), and although the empirical targets are field based, the decision-level outcomes remain conditional on those targets. Priority next steps are primary studies crossing instruments with regions, within-person applicant–incumbent designs, and job-type moderation coded from primary sources.

Study 2's limitations are of a different kind. They concern what the model borrows, not what the data contain. The trait–faking anchors rest on two primary studies with modest samples (n = 128 field; n = 189 laboratory), and the meta-analytic estimates constrain only the Conscientiousness–faking slope; the g and honesty-humility slopes are supported by those primary studies alone. Several trait-model inputs (the confidence compound's correlations with Conscientiousness and integrity, the Agreeableness correlation with social desirability scales) are provisional single-source values, although sensitivity analyses, including a full ±.10 refitting grid on the two confidence-compound correlations, showed the qualitative conclusions did not depend on them. The integrity gap is reported under both published integrity–personality correlation sets because its size, though not its direction, scales with the Conscientiousness–integrity correlation. The falsification check reported in the Results adds a substantive boundary. The shared-slope form overpredicts a negative Emotional Stability–GMA applicant shift in the pooled and non-US conditions, so the model describes Emotional Stability inflation incompletely even where its Conscientiousness component fits. The variance-ratio target is anchored to the Conscientiousness U ratio from the within-subjects applicant-faking meta-analysis (Hu & Connelly, 2021), which narrows but does not eliminate the model's form-dependence. That ratio compares the same people across contexts, whereas the model's quantity is a between-pool ratio, and the published estimate is uncorrected for range restriction and shows wide between-study

heterogeneity. The anchored target favors the ceiling-censored inflation form, and thus the upper half of the US and pooled loss range, but a between-pool variance estimate from matched applicant and incumbent samples would settle the form choice. Finally, the targeted-inflation mechanism satisfies the Agreeableness null by construction; only its trait-general rival was exposed to falsification on that target, so the comparison shows that targeted inflation is *sufficient* and desirability-proportional inflation is *ruled out*, not that targeted inflation is uniquely correct.

A final future direction concerns the technology of faking itself. Applicants have begun using large language models to complete unproctored assessments, and coached models can inflate desirable-trait scores while evading standard faking-detection methods (Robie et al., 2025). Faking as skill is ability-dependent because identifying what a test rewards demands cognitive resources; an assistant that supplies that skill on demand weakens the dependence. In Study 2's terms, widely available AI assistance should push the *g*–faking slope toward zero and may raise prevalence and magnitude simultaneously. The simulation developed here can estimate the costs of such scenarios in advance by re-estimating selection outcomes under a flattened skill gradient, and the meta-analytic approach of Study 1 provides the empirical check. If AI assistance is equalizing faking capability, applicant-pool intercorrelations should shift measurably in future applicant data.

Conclusion

Personality–ability relations differ across assessment contexts. High-stakes assessment shifted personality–ability correlations in construct-specific ways, compensatory for work-competence claims and ability-congruent for confidence claims, within boundaries set by region and instrument family. When the distortion process was modeled, the meta-analytic evidence

rejected trait-general distortion outright, bounded what compensation can accomplish, and revealed that trait-driven faking substitutes lower-integrity hires for higher-integrity ones without appearing in standard selection statistics. Validity–diversity research should use predictor intercorrelations matched to the assessment context and, where possible, model the distortion process instead of importing the correlations it produces.

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Table 1

Meta-Analytic Big Five–GMA Correlations for Applicant and Incumbent Samples and Applicant–Incumbent Contrasts

Trait	k_{app}	N_{app}	$\bar{r}_{app}$ [95% CI]	k_{inc}	N_{inc}	$\bar{r}_{inc}$ [95% CI]	Δ [95% CI]	z	p
Neuroticism	21	22,775	−.11 [−.14, −.08]	83	20,634	−.10 [−.12, −.07]	−.01 [−.06, .03]	−0.61	.540
Extraversion	15	13,137	.02 [−.02, .05]	66	16,822	.03 [.01, .05]	−.01 [−.06, .03]	−0.61	.540
Openness	13	13,756	.14 [.12, .17]	49	10,634	.15 [.12, .18]	.00 [−.04, .04]	−0.15	.881
Agreeableness	11	18,848	.02 [−.02, .05]	64	17,238	.00 [−.03, .02]	+.02 [−.02, .07]	1.05	.294
Conscientiousness	20	20,757	−.07 [−.14, −.00]	71	18,242	.03 [.01, .06]	−.11 [−.18, −.03]	−2.78	.005

Note. Bare-bones psychometric meta-analysis with sample-size weighting. k = number of independent samples; N = total sample size; CI = confidence interval; app = applicant (high-stakes) samples; inc = incumbent samples assessed for research purposes; $\bar{r}$ = N-weighted mean observed correlation; Δ = applicant minus incumbent mean correlation; GMA = general mental ability. Estimates for student, community, and military samples, and contrasts against all pooled low-stakes samples, appear in Supplemental Table S2.

Table 2

Applicant–Incumbent Contrasts for Facets, Aspects, and Compound Traits

Construct	$\bar{r}_{app}$ (*k*)	$\bar{r}_{inc}$ (*k*)	Δ [95% CI]	*z*	*p*
Self-Esteem (compound)	.16 (8)	−.01 (10)	+.17 [.12, .22]	6.25	< .001
Trust (compound)	.15 (7)	−.02 (11)	+.17 [.08, .26]	3.69	< .001
Ambition (compound)	−.08 (5)	.08 (19)	−.16 [−.27, −.05]	−2.78	.005
Sociability (E facet)	−.04 (5)	.01 (33)	−.04 [−.09, .01]	−1.75	.079
Depression (N facet)	−.18 (5)	−.13 (8)	−.05 [−.15, .05]	−0.92	.359
Achievement (C facet)	.07 (8)	.07 (11)	−.01 [−.11, .10]	−0.09	.924
Dependability (C facet)	.04 (5)	.02 (27)	+.02 [−.06, .11]	0.52	.601
Orderliness (C aspect)	−.12 (6)	−.12 (8)	.00 [−.13, .13]	−0.03	.980
Dominance (E facet)	.11 (9)	.09 (32)	+.01 [−.05, .07]	0.40	.690
Intellect (O aspect)	.13 (5)	.17 (8)	−.04 [−.09, .02]	−1.16	.246
Uneven Temper (N facet)	−.08 (8)	−.04 (7)	−.04 [−.11, .03]	−1.10	.271
Factor Alpha	.04 (6)	.06 (13)	−.02 [−.07, .03]	−0.72	.474

Note. All facets, aspects, and compound traits with at least five applicant and five incumbent samples; construct labels follow the Stanek and Ones (2023b) database taxonomy. Contrasts are exploratory and address Research Question 3. *k* = number of independent samples; app = applicant samples; inc = incumbent samples; Δ = applicant minus incumbent mean correlation.

Table 3

Regional Boundary Condition and Context-Matched Intercorrelation Inputs

Panel A: Conscientiousness–GMA Contrasts Within Region

Region	$\bar{r}_{app}$ (k; N)	$\bar{r}_{inc}$ (k; N)	Δ [95% CI]	z	p
United States	.01 (10; 14,707)	.01 (51; 9,664)	−.01 [−.07, .06]	−0.19	.851
Non-US	−.27 (10; 6,050)	.05 (20; 8,577)	−.33 [−.42, −.24]	−7.08	< .001

Panel B: GMA–Big Five Intercorrelation Inputs by Context

Trait	High-stakes r (ρ)	Low-stakes r (ρ)	Total database r (ρ)
Neuroticism	−.11 (−.14)	−.07 (−.08)	−.06 (−.08)
Extraversion	.02 (.02)	−.02 (−.02)	−.01 (−.02)
Openness	.14 (.17)	.19 (.23)	.21 (.26)
Agreeableness	.02 (.02)	−.02 (−.03)	−.01 (−.01)
Conscientiousness	−.07 (−.09)	−.01 (−.01)	.01 (.01)

Note. Panel A addresses Research Question 4; non-US applicant samples are predominantly UK and Australia/New Zealand selection settings using British occupational inventories; within-region contrasts for the remaining Big Five traits were nonsignificant except a small positive US Agreeableness shift (Δ = +.07, 95% CI [.04, .11], z = 4.36); the US Openness contrast could not be estimated (k = 3 applicant samples, below the $k \geq 5$ threshold). Panel B: r = observed N-weighted mean correlation; ρ = corrected for unreliability in both measures (personality reliability = .80, GMA reliability = .85). Given Panel A, the high-stakes Conscientiousness input splits into approximately +.01 (US) and −.27 (non-US). k = number of independent samples; N = total sample size; GMA = general mental ability.

Table 4

Consequences of Applicant Faking for Top-Down Selection in the Study 1 Monte Carlo Simulation

Context	SR	% hires changed	Hire performance, honest	Hire performance, faked	Loss (%)	AIR, honest	AIR, faked
US	.10	35.8	0.61	0.54	10.3	0.40	0.39
US	.30	22.5	0.38	0.35	8.4	0.53	0.52
Pooled	.10	32.3	0.60	0.55	8.9	0.39	0.44
Pooled	.30	22.5	0.39	0.34	10.8	0.53	0.56
Non-US	.10	30.8	0.58	0.49	15.0	0.37	0.52
Non-US	.30	26.0	0.37	0.30	18.7	0.54	0.66

Note. In each condition, faking parameters were fit to reproduce (a) the applicant–incumbent Conscientiousness mean shift, $d = 0.45$ (Birkeland et al., 2006), with 40% faking prevalence (Donovan et al., 2014; Griffith et al., 2007), and (b) the applicant Conscientiousness–GMA correlation estimated in this study for that context (US +.01; pooled −.07; non-US −.27), given honest baseline correlations from incumbent samples (US +.01; pooled +.03; non-US +.05). Faking-noise $\sigma = 0.50$; sensitivity runs varying σ appear in Supplemental Table S7. SR = selection ratio; AIR = adverse-impact ratio (minority-to-majority selection-rate ratio); hire performance is in criterion *SD* units. Adverse-impact ratios use US-derived subgroup parameters in all conditions (see Method). Outcomes compare top-down selection on faked versus honest composites in the same simulated pool ($n = 200{,}000$). Across 25 replications with independent pools, Monte Carlo standard errors of the replication means were at most 0.06 percentage points (% hires changed), 0.19 points (performance loss), and 0.003 (adverse-impact ratio), and the tabled single-pool estimates differed from the replication means by no more than 0.2 points, 1.1 points, and 0.03, respectively. GMA = general mental ability.

Table 5

Fit of Trait–Faking Anchor Sets and Inflation Mechanisms to the Meta-Analytic Applicant Estimates in Study 2

Specification	*r*(*g*, fake)	*r*(C, fake)	*r*(H, fake)	US	Pooled	Non-US
Targeted inflation						
Field	−.19	+.17	−.04	8.17	6.56	6.69
Field, conservative (primary)	−.19	.00	.00	6.20	4.95	4.90
Laboratory	+.14	−.15	+.21	3.79	3.80	6.57
Desirability-proportional inflation						
Field, conservative	−.19	.00	.00	14.12	26.14	68.94
Range across all anchor sets	—	—	—	13.8–15.0	25.5–27.4	67.7–73.2

Note. The first three columns are the target point-biserial correlations between each trait and the faking indicator; the logistic slopes were solved numerically so that each simulated pool reproduces them exactly at 40% prevalence. The last three columns report the minimized weighted least squares distance between the achieved and target values (Conscientiousness $d = 0.45$, Emotional Stability $d = 0.44$, and Agreeableness $d = 0.16$ applicant–incumbent shifts, weighted by their meta-analytic standard errors; applicant Conscientiousness–GMA correlation; Self-Esteem–GMA shift; applicant/honest *SD* ratio of 0.86, from Hu & Connelly, 2021); lower values indicate that the mechanism can reproduce the meta-analytic evidence. Targeted-inflation distances include a fixed component of approximately 3.5 from the Agreeableness target, which that mechanism leaves at zero by construction. Field = point estimates from Holtrop et al. (2021); Laboratory = *g* and honesty-humility estimates from Dunlop et al. (2022), with the Conscientiousness anchor (−.15) taken from the midpoint of the interview-derived laboratory range described in the Method; Field, conservative = the Holtrop et al. point estimates with the two nonsignificant anchors set to zero. *g* = GMA = general mental ability; C = Conscientiousness; H = honesty-humility.

Table 6

Selection Outcomes Under Trait-Driven Faking With Field Anchors and Targeted Inflation in Study 2

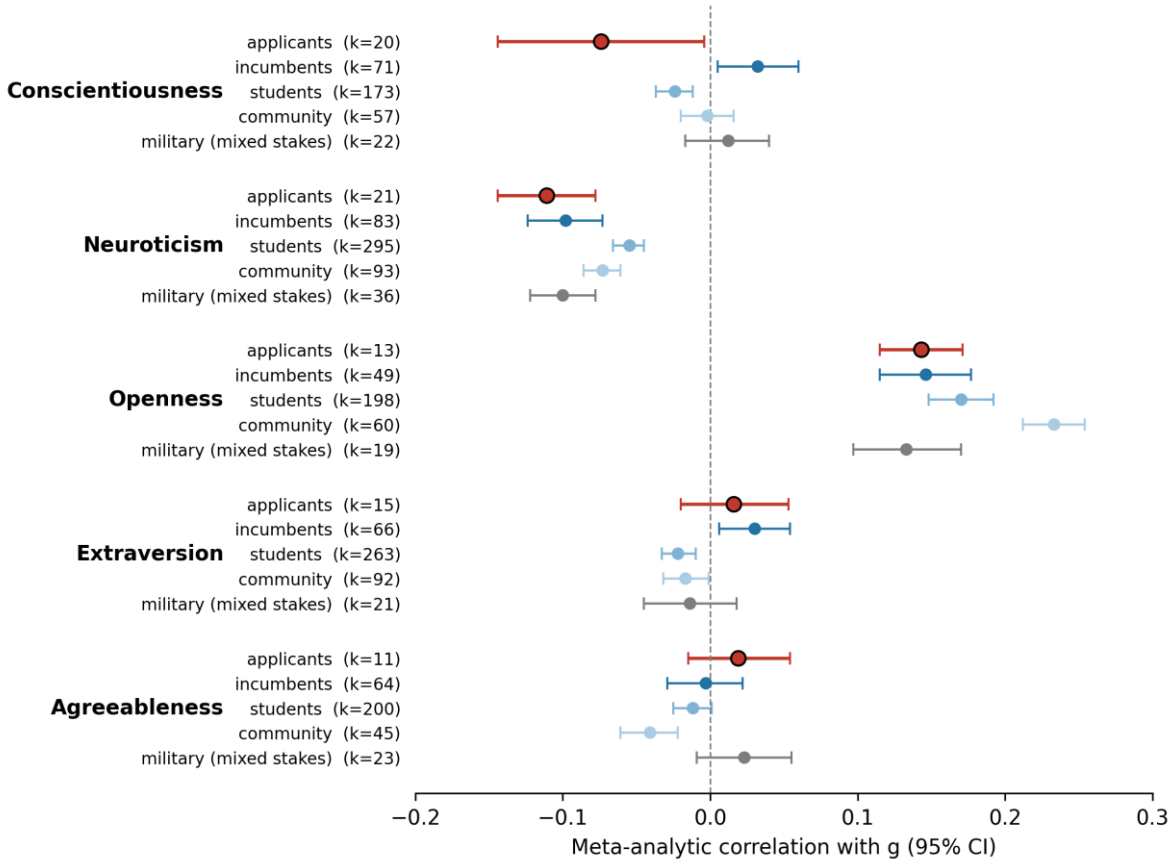
Context	SR	% hires changed	Loss (%)	AIR, honest	AIR, faked	Mean H, faked-in	Mean H, displaced	H gap, HEXACO	H gap, overt tests
US	.10	34.9	10.4	0.40	0.38	+0.08	+0.27	−0.19	−0.32
US	.30	21.1	8.9	0.54	0.53	−0.06	+0.14	−0.19	−0.29
Pooled	.10	28.8	7.9	0.37	0.35	+0.04	+0.26	−0.22	−0.33
Pooled	.30	21.5	9.2	0.52	0.52	−0.04	+0.12	−0.16	−0.30
Non-US	.10	20.0	9.8	0.40	0.37	−0.08	+0.36	−0.45	−0.70
Non-US	.30	25.4	17.9	0.52	0.52	−0.13	+0.19	−0.32	−0.48

Note. Primary specification: field-conservative anchors with targeted inflation, fit per context (Table 5); n = 200,000 per condition. Across 25 replications with independent pools and all parameters re-solved in each, Monte Carlo standard errors of the replication means were at most 0.07 percentage points (% hires changed), 0.19 points (loss), 0.002 (AIR), and 0.004 (mean H). Loss = percentage reduction in mean true performance of hires relative to honest responding in the same pool. Values shown are from the linear inflation form; the ceiling-censored and freed-skill forms, which fit the six empirical targets better in the US and pooled conditions, raise those losses to approximately 13%–18% while leaving non-US values comparable (Supplemental Table S10). SR = selection ratio; AIR = adverse-impact ratio, computed with US-derived subgroup parameters in all conditions (see Study 1 Method); Mean H = mean honesty-humility (in pool *SD* units) of applicants hired only under faking (faked-in) and applicants displaced by them; H gap = mean H of faked-in hires minus mean H of displaced applicants. All columns through H gap, HEXACO use the honesty-humility correlations of Howard and Van Zandt (2020; .25, .14, and .50 with Conscientiousness, Emotional Stability, and Agreeableness). H gap, overt tests = the same quantity from an otherwise identical run (same seed, anchors, and fitting procedure) using the overt integrity-test correlations of Sackett and Wanek (1996, as cited in Lee et al., 2005; .39, .28, and .34); in that run the remaining

columns differed from the tabled values by at most 1.2 percentage points (% hires changed), 0.8 points (loss), and 0.03 (AIR), differences with no consistent direction that reflect the different random draws produced by the changed correlation matrix; the integrity correlations enter those columns only through the small integrity path in the performance model.

Figure 1

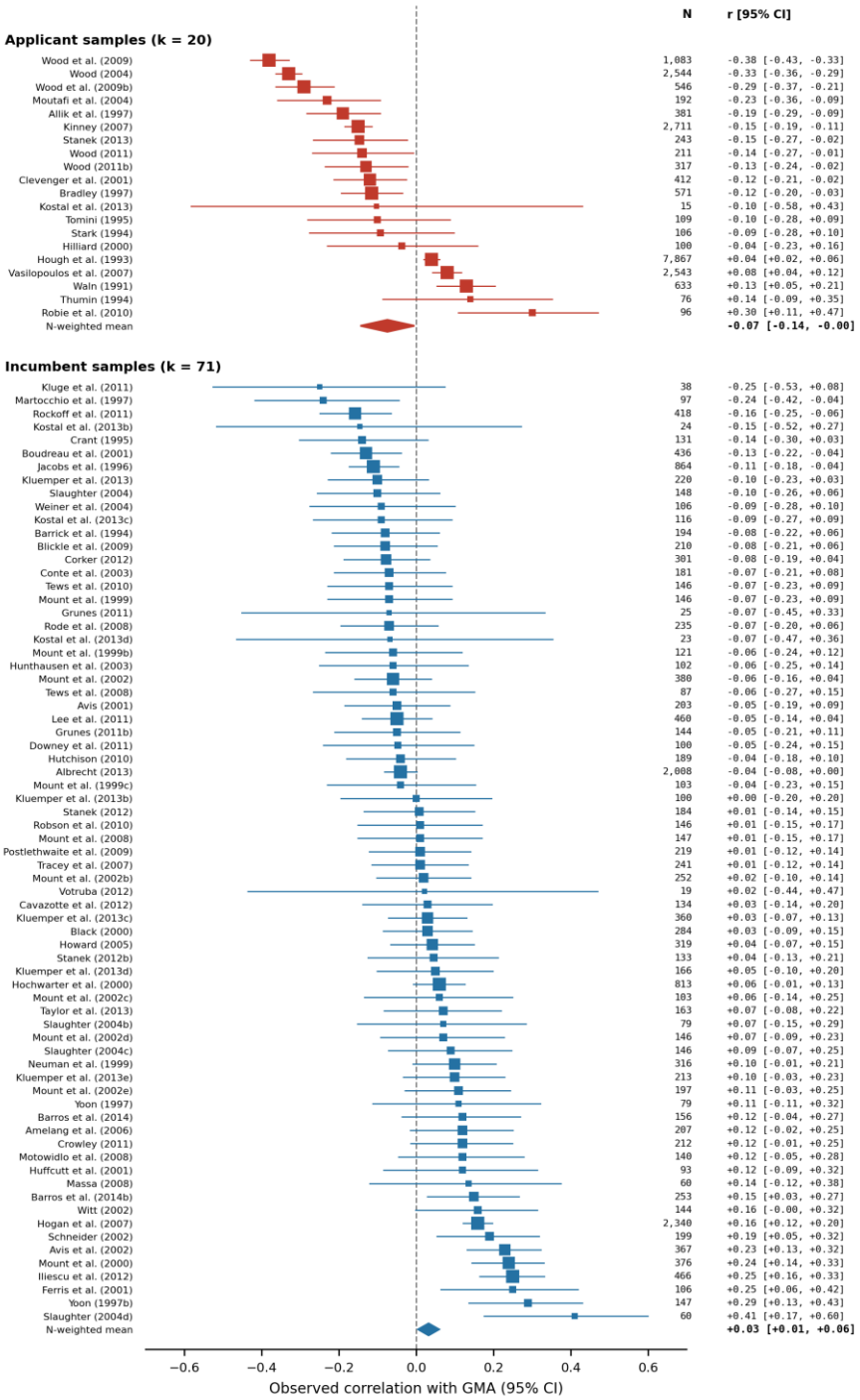
Meta-Analytic Big Five–GMA Correlations by Assessment Context



Note. Bare-bones mean *r* with 95% confidence intervals. Applicant (high-stakes) samples are highlighted. GMA = general mental ability.

Figure 2

Forest Plot of Conscientiousness–GMA Correlations by Sample and Assessment Context

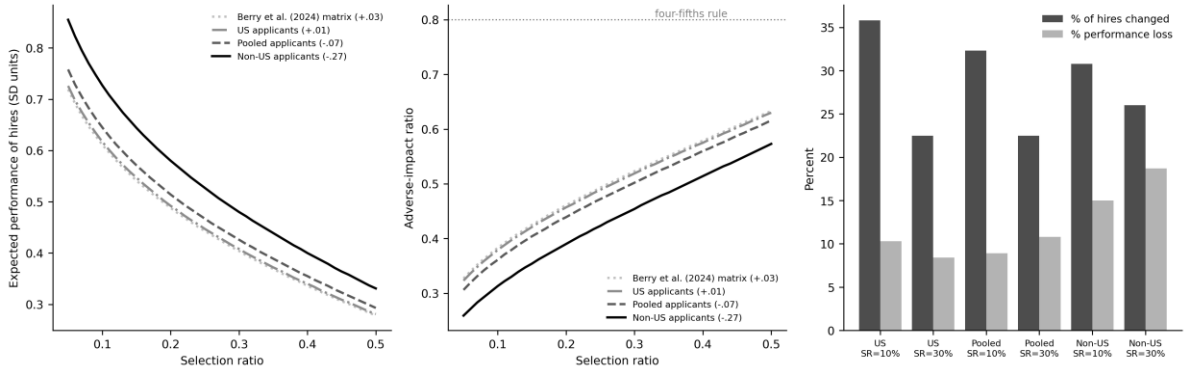


Note. Each row is one independent sample. Squares mark observed correlations, with area proportional to sample size; horizontal lines are 95% confidence intervals from the Fisher *r*-to-*z*

transformation. Diamonds mark the sample-size-weighted mean correlations with 95% confidence intervals and match Table 1. Samples are ordered from most negative to most positive within assessment context. Forest plots for Neuroticism, Openness, Extraversion, and Agreeableness appear in Supplemental Figure S2, Supplemental Figure S3, Supplemental Figure S4, and Supplemental Figure S5, respectively. GMA = general mental ability.

Figure 3

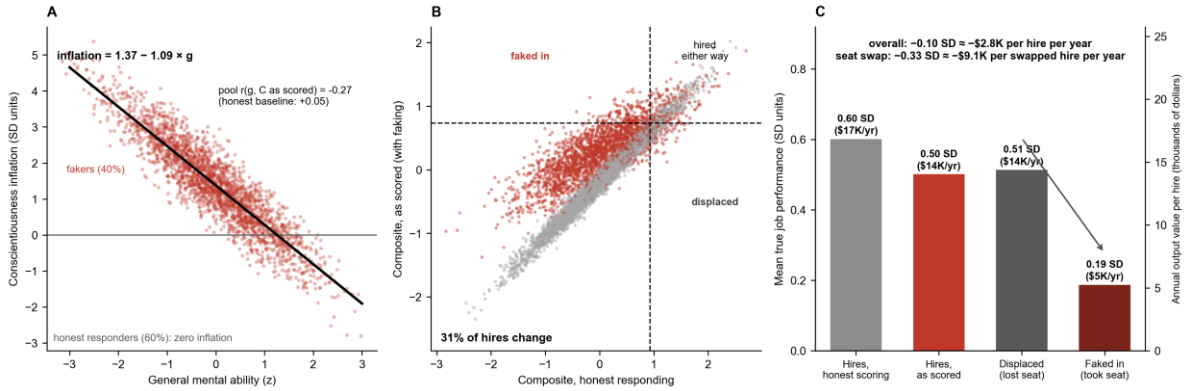
Context-Specific Conscientiousness–GMA Intercorrelations and Top-Down Selection Outcomes



Note. Left and center panels: analytic expected performance of hires and adverse-impact ratio by selection ratio for four intercorrelation inputs: the Berry et al. (2024) matrix value (+.03) and the observed *N*-weighted applicant estimates from this study (US +.01, pooled −.07, non-US −.27); observed values are used because operational validities pair with observed predictor intercorrelations. Right panel: percentage of hiring decisions changed and true performance lost under faking relative to the honest counterfactual, from the Monte Carlo simulation ($\sigma = 0.50$). GMA = general mental ability.

Figure 4

The Mechanism Linking Compensatory Faking to Hiring Consequences



Note. Non-US condition, .10 selection ratio, σ = 0.50, simulated pool n = 200,000. Panel A: among the 40% of applicants who fake, Conscientiousness inflation declines with general mental ability (fitted function shown), turning the pool correlation from +.05 (honest baseline) to −.27 (as scored). Panel B: honest versus as-scored selection composites with top-down cutoffs (dashed lines); points above the horizontal cutoff but left of the vertical cutoff are hires created by faking ("faked in"), and points below the horizontal cutoff but right of the vertical cutoff are applicants displaced by it; 31% of hires change. Panel C: mean true job performance of the hired groups; applicants who faked their way into a seat (M = 0.19 SD) underperform the applicants they displaced (M = 0.51 SD). Dollar values on the right axis convert criterion SD units at SD_y = 40% of an illustrative $70,000 salary (Schmidt & Hunter, 1983). Red points and bars denote fakers or hire sets selected under faked scoring; gray denotes honest responding or honest-scoring counterfactuals.

Appendix

Data Transparency

This study is a secondary analysis of the publicly available Stanek and Ones (2023c) personality–ability relations database (https://doi.org/10.13020/7YS8-ET75), used under a CC BY-NC-ND 3.0 US license. The database is not redistributed; the analyses below report aggregate results. The database's overall meta-analytic relations between personality constructs and cognitive abilities were reported in Stanek and Ones (2023a), and the full construct taxonomy and trait-level syntheses were reported in Stanek and Ones (2023b). Both published syntheses pool across assessment contexts. The following analyses are original to this article and are not reported in either source or elsewhere: (a) moderation of personality–GMA relations by assessment stakes (applicant vs. incumbent, student, community, and military contexts) at the global Big Five level; (b) applicant–incumbent contrasts for facets, aspects, and compound traits; (c) regional, era, and publication-type moderation of the stakes contrasts; (d) stakes- and region-specific intercorrelation inputs corrected for measurement error; and (e) analytic and Monte Carlo modeling of the selection-decision consequences of stakes-specific intercorrelations. No analysis reported here is under review elsewhere, and there is no overlap with any other manuscript based on these data by the same author.